

TRAINED TO PERFECTION: The Railways scores over low-cost airlines in quality food and services

150 km/hr 12

is the speed of the fastest train in the country, the New Delhi-Bhopal Shatabdi Express

is the number of pairs of Shatabdis that the Indian Railways runs. The number is 16 for the Jan-Shatabdi Express.

in Kalka in Himachal Pradesh. The train's interiors are a far cry from the third-class cattle cars that Mahatma Gandhi cannily used, to endorse the virtues of *daridranarayan*—the noble poor. Indeed, when the then Railway minister Madhavrao Scindia introduced the trains during Jawaharlal Nehru's birth centenary in 1988, veterans rang alarums of it going against the Congress culture of austerity. Today, the Congress's fifth generation Rahul Gandhi forsakes his cavalcade of cars to discreetly board the Shatabdi as do governors, film stars and cricketers.

Clocking over 80 kmph, the superfast intercity is second only to its longer-legged cousins—the Rajdhani—in speed, comfort and service. Introduced towards the fag end of India's socialist raj, they were reminders that train travel on the world's densest networks did not have to be a mortifying experience but the state did not have to impose an Emergency to run the railways on time and could occasionally think of its unfortunate middle class who could not afford the state airline.

Today the trains, which ply roughly 1,000 passengers each, between 13 destinations daily, with Rs 465 for the regular chair car and Rs 650 for executive class on the Delhi-Kalka route, represent a fighting chance for the Railways which has seen upper-class passengers being snatched away by low-cost airlines. It takes the train four hours to reach Chandigarh, an airplane would get you there in half-an-hour, but there is the unbearable tedium of driving through the airport, check-in counters, security checks, not to mention circling the congested skies. The Railways has also struck back with the one thing budget airlines have taken away—food and plastic-gloved service.

When the train finally grinds to a halt at Kalka station, a sleepy town of 40,000, the railway line telescopes from broad gauge into narrow and sleek German coaches align near Raj-era wooden box cars. "Welcome to the past, present and future of the Indian Railways," grins station superintendent Ajay Kochchar as passengers, tourists and honeymooners board the narrow-gauge Himalayan Queen to chug up the scenic hills, like the British did a century earlier. Some things should never change. ■

R. PARTHASARATHY, MD of RITES, 1988

"Coaches will be slicker. A better suspension system will ensure fewer jerks and passenger comfort."

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

Over a thousand pairs of eyes mounted on craning necks—business travellers clutching Vaios and Blackberrys, coy newlyweds and tourists totting *Lonely Planets* and Lowe Alpine rucksacks—relax on a misty winter morning on New Delhi railway station's platform number one as the object of their attention, a row of sleek coaches with bug-eyed windows, lazily creeps in. The 2011 New Delhi-Kalka Shatabdi is an air-conditioned, hermetically sealed 15-coach bubble which heads north, through Punjab's capital Chandigarh before chugging to a halt

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